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Heart to Heart: A Comparative Study of and Commentary on the Chinese and Sanskrit *Heart Sutra* Texts

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A comprehensive comparison of the Chinese and Sanskrit texts of the *Heart Sutra* shows that, even after correcting transmission errors, there are substantial differences between them. Most of the differences appear to arise from the process of translating the text from Chinese to Sanskrit in isolation from Sanskrit Prajñāpāramitā literary traditions. Some differences appear to reflect the differing doctrinal commitments of those involved in creating/transmitting the texts. Following a suggestion by Huifeng (2014), I take a phenomenological approach when reading the *Heart Sutra*, effectively creating a new kind of commentary that eschews the usual references to metaphysics, mysticism, and magic. The focus here is on the phenomenology of sensory experience and especially the cessation of sensory experience in meditation.

Preamble

The *Heart Sutra* is one of the most recognisable Buddhist texts. Until recently, it was thought to have been composed in India in the second or third century CE,[1] although both of these dates were debunked by Watanabe Shōgo (1990) who concluded that the version attributed to Xuánzàng (602–664 CE) is the oldest *Heart Sutra*. There has also been some debate about the provenance of the text, which has been the focus of previous comparative studies (Nattier 1992, Huifeng 2014, and Attwood 2021b). These studies have established, contra received accounts and

1. There are two main scholarly opinions on which is the earliest "translation." Fukui Fumimasa 1987) and other Japanese scholars credit the fictitious "lost translation" by Zhī Qiān 支謙 (fl. 222–254 CE) as the earliest, while Conze and other European scholars took the earliest "translation" to be the *Móhē bānrě bōluómì dàmíngzhòu jīng* «摩訶般若波羅蜜大明呪經» (T250), and further assumed that it was translated by Kumārajīva (or one of his followers) based on a manuscript obtained in the fourth century. In both cases the date of composition is obtained by the dubious method of subtracting a century from the earliest Chinese date.

Keywords: Heart Sutra, Xīn jīng, Prajñāpāramitāhṛdaya, comparative, phenomenology

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scholarly apologetics,[2] that the *Heart Sutra* was composed in Chinese in the mid-seventh century, probably by Xuánzàng, and later translated (back) into Sanskrit. This conclusion is supported by comments made by the early commentators[3] and by the distribution and chronology of the earliest evidence.[4]

In this article, I return to comparing the Chinese and Sanskrit versions of the *Heart Sutra*, with a view to moving beyond the "origins" debate. There are significant differences between the Chinese and Sanskrit *Heart Sutra* texts that, to my knowledge, have not been studied or commented on before. For the purposes of this study, I have divided the text into five sections, but within each section, I comment on smaller units, from sentences down to individual words.

At face value, this method seems straightforward enough and we may wonder why it was not tried before in the 150-year history of Anglophone *Heart Sutra* scholarship. Indeed, Watanabe (2021, 23-24) recently said: "A more detailed comparative examination of the differences between the Chinese translations and the Sanskrit text is needed." Note, however, that like many of his Japanese colleagues, Watanabe explicitly rejects the Chinese origins of the *Heart Sutra*. For this faction, the focus is always on what they call "the Sanskrit original."[5] Those who agree with Nattier (1992) seem to be unwilling to publicly endorse Chinese origins, even when they are privately convinced. A notable exception is Sarah Mattice (2021) who does a credible job assessing Nattier's argument and noting that it is extremely plausible. Daniel Boucher (2017, 506) has also cautiously expressed that Nattier might be right.[6]

Some textual problems make comparisons difficult. For example, Conze's Sanskrit edition has numerous reported grammatical errors (Nattier 1992, Huifeng 2014, Attwood 2015, etc.). These errors are simply reproduced without comment by other scholars when they publish editions of the text.[7] Huifeng (2014) also showed that there were problems with the Chinese text (discussed below). My revised editions of the Sanskrit and Chinese Heart Sutra texts are slated to appear in Asian Literature and Translation in 2024. The revised Sanskrit edition is fully parsable, unlike any

2. See for example Fukui (1987), Harada (2010), Saitō (2021), and Watanabe (2021). Compare also Nattier's (1995) (unpublished) rebuttal of a critique published by Fukui in 1994 (I don't have a copy of this article which is in Japanese). On the reception of Nattier's (1992) article amongst the Buddhist clergy in Japanese academia, see also the pertinent observations made by Frederik Schodt (2020, 118–145).

3. See Nattier (1992, 206–207, n. 33). I have completed a more detailed study of how the early commentators—Kuījī 窺基, Woncheuk 圓測, Fǎzàng 法藏, and Jìngmài 靖邁—saw the issue of provenance and hope to publish the results in 2024.

4. I have also completed a study of the earliest evidence for the *Heart Sutra* and hope to publish this in 2024.

5. The role of "the Sanskrit original" in the philology of Buddhist texts has been called into question by Jonathan Silk (2015, 215): "If, as I have suggested, there is no singular original, no Urtext, for Buddhist sūtras, neither Āgamic nor those generated by Mahāyāna movements, there can consequently be no archetype. This implies that it is simply not possible to eclectically reconstruct a text." However, Silk (2015, 217) also mentions in passing that "the *Heart Sūtra* revered in Japan is a Chinese translation from Sanskrit... ."

6. Nattier (2003, xi) describes how she and (then PhD student) Boucher formed a reading group at Indiana University in the 1990s.

7. For example, Saitō 2021

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of the earlier editions. The following discussion of the differences between the two texts is based on these revised editions.

Another reason for the neglect of comparative studies may be that the standard *Heart Sutra* hermeneutic involves adopting a metaphysics in which "the mystical identity of opposites" or "the oneness of all" (Conze 1958, 83–84) are axiomatic. This "mystical identity" is "communicated" by asserting contradictory statements. Since this approach tells us that differences are actually *samenesses* (and vice versa), further inquiry leads only to restating Conze's axiom "A is what A is not" (Conze 1958, 84). In the meantime, Paul Harrison (2006) has shown that Conze misinterpreted Sanskrit compounds in the *Vajracchedikā Prajñāpāramitā*, creating contradictions where none were intended. I have shown that he did something similar in the *Heart Sutra* (Attwood 2020b). Contradiction plays no important role in either text. My sense is that this applies to Prajñāpāramitā more generally.

A related problem has been referred to as "the Madhyamaka telos" (Huifeng 2016). This is the view that, for all intents and purposes, Prajñāpāramitā *is* Madhyamaka or at least proto-Madhyamaka. For example: "The Mādhyamika philosophy had been in complete harmony with the teaching of the Prajñāpāramitā Sūtras" (Conze 1978, 104). An obvious example of this approach is the Dalai Lama's *Heart Sutra* commentary (Gyatso 2002), which consists mainly of a breezy introduction to Tibetan Buddhism and an exposition of Madhyamaka doctrine.[8] Exposition of Madhyamaka is very popular in Buddhist Studies, with numerous ongoing lines of research but there is a corresponding paucity of research that looks at Prajñāpāramitā qua Prajñāpāramitā. I do not look to Madhyamaka metaphysics for an understanding of Prajñāpāramitā, rather I have tried to read the *Heart Sutra* in terms drawn from Prajñāpāramitā itself. My approach frames the *Heart Sutra* (and Prajñāpāramitā more broadly) in terms of the phenomenology of meditation, focussing on the cessation (*nirodha*) of sensory experience and the subsequent state of "absence" (*śūnyatā*). This approach to reading Prajñāpāramitā emerged from applying a methodology developed by Sue Hamilton for reading Pāli suttas.[9] Hamilton (2000) argued that "the Buddha"[10] was talking about experience rather than reality, that is, about epistemology or phenomenology, not about ontology or metaphysics. Reading Prajñāpāramitā in this way first appeared plausible to me after studying Huifeng (2014). For example, Huifeng pointed out that Kumārajīva coined the term *yǐwúsuǒdégù* 以無所得故 to translate *anupalambhayogena* "through prac-

8. Orsborn (2022) makes clear that the *Dàzhìdù lùn* «大智度論» (T1509), the most influential Prajñāpāramitā commentary in East Asia, is a Madhyamaka commentary on Prajñāpāramitā, which includes a great deal of Sarvāstivāda Abhidharma analysis. The *Abhisamayālaṅkāra* is traditionally said to have been written by Maitreyanātha or Asaṅga (Conze 1978, 95), early proponents of Yogācāra doctrine, but this commentary also treats Prajñāpāramitā in largely Madhyamaka terms.

9. Sue Hamilton died in 2016. Her book owed an unacknowledged debt to an earlier article by Rupert Gethin (1986) that anticipates some of her conclusions about the *skandhas* and experience.

10. Here I only intend to reference the main character of the Pāli suttas. Regarding the historicity of the Buddha, I concur with David Drewes (2017) that until the Buddha can be linked to some historical fact or event, it is incoherent for historians to speak of "the historical Buddha."

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tising nonapprehension" rather than the expression in the Sanskrit *Heart Sutra*, *aprāptitvāt* "because of nonattainment." He notes that this change also suggests seeing *yǐwúsuǒdégù* as qualifying the negated lists that precede it. As Huifeng puts it:

> It is our view that this shifts the emphasis from an ontological negation of classical lists, i.e., 'there is no X', to an epistemological stance. That is, when the bodhisattva is 'in emptiness', i.e., in the contemplative meditation of the emptiness of phenomena, he is 'engaged in the non-apprehension' of these phenomena. (2014, 103)

I have elsewhere attempted to demonstrate the explanatory power of this approach, although rather than an "epistemological stance," I see it as a *phenomenological approach* (Attwood 2022a). In this hermeneutic, we assume that the subject matter is *what we experience*, particularly in meditation, rather than *what exists or is real*. This approach is not a form of idealism, it does not assert the superiority of experience over reality. The phenomenological approach is pragmatic: the cessation of sensory experience is the focus of Prajñāpāramitā because this is the culmination of Buddhist meditation. Indeed, I have argued that *prajñā* is precisely the knowledge gained from undergoing cessation and being in the absence of sensory experience.

This change in focus is not without ramifications. For example, we cannot simply continue using translations that are rooted in the existing paradigm. It is notable, for example, that Hamilton's approach entailed redefining the *skandhas* in experiential terms.[11] Traditionally, the *skandhas* have been seen as a complete ontology, though Hamilton characterised them as "the experiencing apparatus" (96), that is, the processes by which we have sensory experiences. While I appreciate Hamilton's contribution, I have concluded that she underplayed the role of the cessation (*nirodha*) of sensory experience and the subsequent state in which experience is absent, known in Pāli as *suññatāvihāra* and Sanskrit as *śūnyatāsamādhi*.[12] In my revised editions and translations of the *Heart Sutra* (Attwood forthcoming), I propose reading the text as being concerned with experience and, especially, the cessation of sensory experience in meditation, the text begins to make plain sense, without the handwaving required by repudiating the principle of noncontradiction.

My attempts to move beyond the existing paradigms for understanding the *Heart Sutra*—through both criticising existing methods and conclusions and by developing the phenomenological approach which leads to very different methods and conclusions—have met with very limited success to date. We seem to be stuck in a time warp, in which Nattier's thirty-year-old conclusions are somehow construed as being unclear or unproven, despite the brilliant clarity of the article and independent confirmation of the accuracy of its hypothesis (Huifeng 2014, Attwood 2017, etc.).

11. Hamilton was led to her conclusions by the realisation that the received explanations of doctrines such as *anātman* and the *skandhas* appeared to be incoherent. A close reading of the Pāli passages that refer to the *skandhas* does not support the traditional interpretations. For a summary of her views on the *skandhas*, see Hamilton 2000: 70–78.

12. On these terms see discussions in Anālayo 2015, 2022, and Huifeng 2016.

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To be clear, all scholars (both ancient and modern) agree that some passages in the *Heart Sutra* were copied from a *Large Prajñāpāramitā Sutra* (hereafter *Large Sutra*). Most obviously, what Nattier called the "core passage"[13] of the *Heart Sutra* is indisputably copied from a version of the *Large Sutra*. Nattier compared the core passage as it appears in four texts. Since that time, some of the sources that Nattier relied on have been updated. Notably, we have two new sources for the *Pañcaviṃśatisāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā*: the facsimile edition of the Gilgit manuscript, edited by Karashima *et al.* (2016);[14] and Kimura's eclectic edition of the later Nepalese manuscripts (1986-2007, I-1 64–65). I will also rely on my revised edition of the Sanskrit *Heart Sutra* (Attwood forthcoming). The four texts Nattier examined were:

1. *Pañcaviṃśatisāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā (Pañc)*
2. *Móhē bānrě bōluómì jīng* «般若波羅蜜經» *(Móhē)*[15]
3. *Prajñāpāramitāhṛdaya (Hṛd)*
4. *Bānrě bōluómìduō xīn jīng* «般若波羅蜜多心經» *(Xīn)*[16]

A comparative reading of the core passage shows that *Hṛd* frequently has very different lexical and syntactic choices compared to the corresponding passage in *Pañc*, and that *Xīn* is correspondingly very similar, if not identical, to *Móhē*. If there was copying, as we all agree, then this tells us that the copying happened in Chinese. Moreover, there is a pattern in the differences between the two Sanskrit texts. *Hṛd* routinely adopts unusual idioms that are not found at all in *Pañc* (or anywhere else), but which are nevertheless synonymous with expressions that do occur there. These unmatched synonyms are precisely what we expect if the passage in question had been translated from Sanskrit to Chinese, extracted in Chinese, and then independently translated back into Sanskrit: a process known as back-translation.

Nattier's observations have been independently confirmed by Huifeng (2014) and Attwood (2017b, 2018b, 2020a). The whole argument is restated in a streamlined form, incorporating all the independent confirmations, in Attwood (2021b). Notably, in Attwood (2018b) I observed that *Hṛd* contains a calque of an expression coined by Chinese Buddhist translators. Sarah Mattice's (2021, 8–17) positive assessment of Nattier's argument is useful, but in her follow-up section, "Responses to Nattier," Mattice (2021, 17–24) overlooks precisely the independent confirmations of Nattier by Huifeng and Attwood, focussing instead on marginal publications that I will mention only in passing here, if at all.

There is no doubt that the *Heart Sutra* was composed in Chinese and back-translated into Sanskrit. We do not know who was responsible for either *Xīn* or *Hṛd*,

13. The "core passage" (T251 [8] 848c7-c13) covers about half the text from the first *Shèlìzi* 舍利子 down to *yì wú dé* 亦無得。.

14. See also Zacchetti's (2005, 393) partial transcription of the Gilgit manuscript, which covers the "core section" of *Hṛd*.

15. T223 (8) 223a13-a20; translated by Kumārajīva 404CE. Regarding the transcription of 般若, I follow the recommendation of the *Digital Dictionary of Buddhism*: "the Pinyin spelling *bānrě* (from *pan + ɲia'* rather than *pan* or *pa + ɲiak*) has come to be preferred in many scholarly circles." http://www.buddhism-dict.net/cgi-bin/xpr-ddb.pl?q=般若. See also the note in Zacchetti 2005, 3 n. 5.

16. T251 (8) 848c3-c22; apocryphally attributed to Xuánzàng.

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but the earliest evidence is all strongly linked to Xuánzàng, and he is still the only viable suspect.[17]

Since my alternative to the normative interpretation of the *Heart Sutra* has attracted no converts (in print at least), I still have to explain a great deal as I go. This involves brief recapitulations of arguments made in detail elsewhere. In this reading, established definitions and translations of certain technical terms (including *śūnyatā*, *svabhāva*, *skandha*, and *rūpa*) need to be revisited. While not strictly necessary, it would be advantageous for the reader to be familiar with Nattier (1992), Huifeng (2014), and Attwood (2020c, 2021b and 2022a) before reading this article.

Opening

> 觀自在菩薩行深般若波羅蜜多時，照見五蘊皆空，度一切苦厄。
>
> Bodhisatva Guanyin was practising the deep perfection of insight practice and looked for the *skandha*s, all were absent, he transcended all suffering.
>
> āryāvalokiteśvaro *bodhisatvo gambhīrāṃ prajñāpāramitācaryāṃ caramāṇo vyavalokayati sma pañcaskandhāṃs tāṃś ca svabhāvaśūnyān paśyati sma* |
>
> Bodhisatva Noble Avalokiteśvara, practising the deep practice of perfect insight, examined the five *skandha*s and saw that they were empty of essence.

The first sentence of both *Xīn* and *Hṛd* contains three clauses, but they only have two in common. The third clause in *Xīn* (度一切苦厄 "he transcended all suffering") has no Sanskrit counterpart, and the second clause in *Xīn* has become two clauses in *Hṛd*.

Note that the revised edition has *pañcaskandhān* (accusative plural; with sandhi the ending becomes *-āṃs*) as the object of *vyavalokayati sma* "he examined."[18] Without this alteration, the text of this sentence in *Hṛd* does not make sense. This section introduces several important themes and terms: practice, the *skandha*s, emptiness.

Practising

The first clause of the first sentence of *Xīn* has a simple structure: subject, verb, adjective, object, qualifier: "When/While (*shí* 時) Avalokiteśvara Bodhisatva (*Guānzìzài púsà* 觀自在菩薩)[19] practised (*xíng* 行) deep (*shēn* 深) perfection of insight

17. In a forthcoming article, I will examine the oldest archaeological evidence alongside the oldest mentions of the *Heart Sutra* in commentaries, catalogue records, and other relevant literature. In each case, the evidence comes from China in the mid-late seventh century and either names Xuánzàng or was composed by one of his close associates.

18. Conze's (1948, 34; 1967, 150) edition has *pañcaskandhās* (nominative plural). In the nominative case, the word has no comprehensible relationship to the rest of the sentence and, at the same time, the transitive verb *vyavalokayati sma* "he examined" lacks an object. Conze's translation simply treats the verb as intransitive, "he looked down," and he adds an extra verb "beheld" to deal with the grammatically disconnected *pañcaskandhās*. Changing *pañcaskandhās* to the accusative *pañcaskandhāṃs* resolves all these problems (Attwood 2015, 43-45). Saitō (2021, 13-18) mentions my description of the problem and proposed solution, but he equivocates and inexplicably retains the faulty text in his Sanskrit edition.

19. *Púsà* 菩薩is an abbreviation of *pútísàduǒ* 菩提薩埵 (which occurs in section 3). On Chinese translations of Avalokiteśvara, see Nattier (2007) and Karashima (2017).

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(*bānrě bōluómìduō* 深般若波羅蜜多)." *Hṛd* complicates this by referring to "practising the practice of..." (*caryāṃ caramāṇo*). Similar phrases are found in *Pañc*, for example, *bodhisattvacaryāṃ caran* (Kimura 1986–2007, I-2 93) or *brahmacaryaṃ caranti* (Kimura 1986–2007, V 43). However, they are not common. The term *prajñāpāramitācaryā* occurs just once in *Pañc* (Kimura 1986–2007, V 111) and not at all in the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā* (*Aṣṭa*).[20] This suggests that *Hṛd* was not drawing on the Sanskrit idiom of *Pañc*.

Xíng 行 is the most common translation for Sanskrit words derived from √*car* "move, go, walk, etc." The qualification of the verb *xíng* 行 by *shí* 時 tells us that this is a subordinate clause. In *Hṛd* this is conveyed by using the present middle participle, *caramāṇa*. We do not find this participle in *Pañc* or *Aṣṭa*, but we do find the present active form: *caranta* (Kimura 1986–2007, IV 32; Vaidya 1960, 14). In translations from Chinese, we often see *shēn* 深 taken to be an adverb of *xíng* 行, "deeply practising" whereas, in *Hṛd*, *gambhīra* is an adjective of *Prajñāpāramitā,* "deep *Prajñāpāramitā.*" In the broader Prajñāpāramitā context, we expect *gambhīrāṃ prajñāpāramitāṃ*.[21]

Seeing, self-existence, and absence

Xīn says, "[He] examined the five *skandha*s, all [were] empty" (*zhàojiàn wǔyùn jiē kōng* 照見五蘊皆空). Most translations from Chinese treat this as one phrase: "he saw that the five *skandha*s [were] all empty." *Hṛd* treats this as two phrases: "he examined the five branches of experience" (*vyavalokayati sma pañcaskandhāṃs = zhàojiàn wǔyùn* 照見五蘊) "*and* he saw them lacking self-existence" (*tāṃś ca svabhāvaśūnyān paśyati sma = jiē kōng* 皆空).

Understanding, and thus translating, the term *zhàojiàn* 照見 has been problematic. Some translators/commentators opt to treat it as two words, for example, "saw clearly" (Mattice 2021, 198), though as an adverb, we might expect *zhào* 照 to mean something more like "brightly" or "visibly" since the basic meaning is "bright" and it is commonly used to mean "shine upon, illuminate." Mattice (2021, 201) explains, "[Guanyin] sees clearly, she observes, in fact, she illuminates something for all of us about the five *yun* 蘊." Hyun Choo (2006, 142), translating Woncheuk's commentary (T1711), renders the phrase as "illuminatingly sees." Woncheuk himself does not comment on *zhàojiàn* 照見 and Kuījī comments only on the character *zhào dá kōng míng* 照達空名 "[*zhào*] means penetrating into emptiness" (1710 (33) 535b11; Shih and Lusthaus 2001, 81). Another two-word approach is found in Leon Hurvitz's (1977, 107) translation of *zhàojiàn* 照見 as an adjective-noun combination: "had an

20. It is, however, used frequently in the *Suvikrāntavikrāmiparipṛcchā* and the Gilgit manuscript of the *Aṣṭādaśasāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā*. This raises the possibility of influence from these texts, but this remains an open question. Respectively, the texts can be found online at: http://gretil.sub.unigoettingen.de/gretil/corpustei/transformations/html/sa_suvikrAntavikrAmiparipRcchA.htm and http://gretil.sub.uni-goettingen.de/gretil/1_sanskr/4_rellit/buddh/adsp55-u.htm. Accessed 17 Oct 2022.

21. For example, from Kimura (1986–2007): *yo hi kaścit kauśika kulaputro vā kuladuhitā vā imāṃ gambhīrāṃ prajñāpāramitām* (II–III, 54); *ya ime bhagavan mohapuruṣā gambhirāṃ prajñāpāramitāṃ pratibādhiṣyanti* (II–III, 153); *evaṃ gambhīrāṃ prajñāpāramitāṃ śrutvā* (IV, 9).

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illuminating vision." This necessitates the addition of an auxiliary verb "had" otherwise the sentence would lack a verb. Although there is some flexibility in Chinese, where some expressions can be used adjectivally and verbally, the lack of a verb here leaves the sentence incomplete. Shih and Lusthaus's (2001, 81) translation of the embedded text in Kuījī's commentary (T1710) and Stephen Teiser's (2000, 113) translation of *Xīn* both follow Hurvitz.

The counterpart in *Hṛd* suggests that the author perceived the two characters *zhàojiàn* 照見 as reflecting a single complex Sanskrit verb—*vyavalokayati* "to examine"—rather than an adverb-verb or adjective-noun combination. Such two-character expressions in Chinese are referred to as binomial. In which case, perhaps the translation refers to *zhào* 照 in the sense of definition (4) from Kroll (2015, 595): "inspect, regard, look carefully at; perceive, be conscious of." Added to the basic sense of *jiàn* 見 "see," this suggests a binomial meaning something like "looking closely at, examining," similar to the Sanskrit *vyavalokayati*. Another possibility is that *zhàojiàn* 照見 might reflect a "double translation," where one word is translated by two synonyms—here "inspect" and "see"—as a kind of auto-commentary or to reflect the range of meanings of the original term. Stephen West (2000, 116) appears to take this kind of approach in his translation "shining upon and making manifest." *Zhàojiàn* 照見 is used in several other Chinese Buddhist translations and it would be useful for a qualified scholar to identify, if possible, which Indic terms it translates in these cases.

Hṛd uses the term *svabhāvaśūnya* "empty of self-existence," though *Xīn* does not use the parallel Chinese term *zìxìng* 自性 "self-existence" at all. *Kōng* 空/*śūnyatā* is almost always translated as "emptiness," regardless of context, and is assumed to be a reference to the Madhyamaka idea that all *dharmas* (qua phenomena) are (ultimately) unreal or non-existent because they lack *svabhāva* in the sense of being autopoietic or self-creating. We can infer from this that the back-translator understood "emptiness" (*kōng* 空) as a reference to Madhyamaka doctrine.

The basic sense of *śūnya* (Pāli *suñña*) is that *something is absent*.[22] For example, an "empty house" (*suññāgāra*, *suññageha*) is a house whose occupants are absent. Common synonyms in a Buddhist context include *ritta* "devoid, empty of," *tuccha* "empty, vain, deserted," and *asāra* "worthless, insubstantial."[23] The abstract noun, *śūnyatā*, reflects the quality of absence. In Attwood (2022a, 125), I argued that in a *Prajñāpāramitā* context, *śūnyatā* was used in much the same sense as the Pāli term *suññatāvihāra*, "dwelling in absence," found in the *Cūḷasuññata Sutta* (M 121).[24] This term refers to a state in which no sensory phenomena are present (*asuñña*), or in other words when all sensory experience is absent (*suñña*). This absence (*suññatā*) is brought about by "inattention" to sensory experience (*amanasikāra*; on which

22. While it is common to cite an etymology here, often the one proposed by Conze (1958, 80), in fact the word is never used in the sense of "swelling."

23. See for example, S IV.173: "He would see an empty village. Whatever house he enters is devoid, deserted, empty" (*So passeyya suññaṃ gāmaṃ. Yaññadeva gharaṃ paviseyya rittakaññeva paviseyya tucchakaññeva paviseyya suññakaññeva paviseyya*).

24. There is a Chinese counterpart in *Xiǎo kōng jīng* «小空經» MĀ 190 (T26 [I] 736c29–738a2); MĀ is translated into English in Anālayo (2015).

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see Anālayo 2022) or "non-apprehension" of sensory experience (*anupalambha*; see Huifeng 2014; Attwood 2022a).

As discussed by Ronkin (2005) and Cox (2004), prior to Nāgārjuna, Buddhists, including Ābhidharmikas, did not use *svabhāva* to mean autopoietic.[25] The word is not used in the Pāli suttas but is found in some early paracanonical works, such as the *Paṭsambhidāmagga*, *Peṭakopadesa*, *Nettipakaraṇa*, and *Milindapañha*. Ronkin (2005, 105-107) discusses four interrelated senses of the early use of *svabhāva*: nature, essence, *sui generis*, and true. However, Ronkin (2005, 87) emphasises that, despite this language, the primary interest was epistemological rather than ontological. In this view, *svabhāva* concerns the properties or qualities of phenomena rather than objects or noumena. In other words, echoing Hamilton (2000), the nature of experience rather than the nature of reality. Distinctions that are central to Buddhist soteriology—such as the one between greed and generosity—are based on the *sui generis* nature of such experiences: we *know* when we experience greed or generosity because such experiences have distinctive, identifiable, characteristics. In this view, *a* dharma ("an element of experience") has *svabhāva* to the extent we can identify it. This definition lacks the kind of metaphysical commitments entailed by the Madhyamaka view that no dharma can possess *svabhāva* in the sense of "self-creation," which is sometimes taken to mean that dharmas do not exist. Generally speaking, Prajñāpāramitā texts do not discuss the phenomenology of experience in (dualistic) metaphysical terms such as "existence" or "nonexistence." In *Aṣṭa*, for example, we often find the Elder Subhūti stating that he does not know, apprehend, or perceive a dharma.[26] We never find him debating the *existence* or *reality* of dharmas, one way or the other. It is only when we reify dharmas that their existence or non-existence becomes a topic of discussion.

We do not know whether the author of *Aṣṭa* understood *svabhāva* to mean *autopoiesis*, *sui generis*, or some other sense, since this has not, to my knowledge, been studied. However, since the term *zìxìng* 自性 is absent from *Xīn* we can infer that it was not intended to be included or considered in this context. The presence of *svabhāva* in *Hṛd* could be evidence of an interpolation of Madhyamaka doctrine.[27]

Transcending suffering

The first sentence of *Xīn* concludes with the phrase *dù yīqiè kǔ è* 度一切苦厄 "[he] transcended all suffering." This phrase has no counterpart in any version of *Hṛd*. As we shall see below (Section 4.2), it means much the same as *sarvaduḥkhapraśamanaḥ* "pacifies all suffering." As Sue Hamilton writes about the early Buddhist use of the term, "*dukkha* is not contingent to experience. Rather, one cannot have experience that is not *dukkha*" (Hamilton 2000, 68) and "*dukkha* is better understood as *the fact of*

25. Ronkin (2005, 86–131) discusses temporal changes to the term in Pāli texts, including the Abhidhamma. Collett Cox (2004), does the same based on Sarvāstivāda Abhidharma sources.

26. For example: *evam apy aham enān āyuṣman śāriputra dharmān na vedmi, nopalabhe, na samanupaśyāmi* (Vaidya 1960, 178).

27. A study of how *svabhāva* is used in Prajñāpāramitā is required to know in what sense the term was being used in that literature.

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experience" (Hamilton 2000, 71. Emphasis added). In this view, transcending *duḥkha* is tantamount to transcending sensory experience, which I take to be the principal topic of the *Heart Sutra*.

This phrase also occurs in the anonymously translated *Dàfāngguǎng shílún jīng* «大方廣十輪經» **Daśacakra-kṣitigarbha Sūtra*, that is, *yì néng jì dù yīqiè kǔ è* 亦能濟度一切苦厄 (T410 [13] 708a24–a27). Although we do not have a Sanskrit text of the **Daśacakra-kṣitigarbha Sūtra*, the sutra was also translated by Xuánzàng, who rendered this phrase as *zì qiú jiě tuō yīqiè yōu kǔ* 自求解脫一切憂苦 (T411 [13] 754a12-16). Here, *tuō* 脫 suggests a different verb, perhaps one derived from √*muc* or √*mokṣ* "liberated, freed; etc." Xuánzàng has a reputation for accurately reflecting his source texts in his translations, which suggests that he may have been translating something like **sarvaduḥkhāt vimuktaḥ*.[28] Whichever way we look at it, the absence of this phrase from *Hṛd* and its presence in *Xīn* is curious. This oddity is not commented on by Woncheuk, even though he ostensibly had a Sanskrit text.

The core section

The core section was the focus of Nattier's (1992) investigation. It comprises about half the text and was copied from chapter three of Kumārajīva's Chinese translation of a *Large Sutra* (T223 [8] 223a13–a24). As throughout the *Heart Sutra*, some words in the passage have been replaced with Xuánzàng's preferred choice of characters, for example, Śāriputra was traditionally Shèlìfú 舍利弗 but Xuánzàng preferred Shèlìzi 舍利子.

Appearance is absence

The first part of the core section is different in the two texts:

> 舍利子，色不異空空不異色色即是空空即是色。受想行識亦復如是。
>
> Appearance is not different from absence; absence is not different from appearance. Appearance is just absence; absence is just appearance. Valence, recognition, volition, and discrimination are the same.
>
> *iha śāriputra rūpaṃ śūnyatā śūnyataiva rūpaṃ rūpān na pṛthak śūnyatā śūnyatāyā na pṛthag rūpaṃ | evam eva vedanā-saṃjñā-saṃskāra-vijñānaṃ |*
>
> Here, Śāriputra, appearance is absence; absence is only appearance. Absence is not different from appearance; appearance is not different from absence. So also for valence, recognition, volition, and discrimination.

Elsewhere (Attwood 2017b, 64–67), I have pointed out several anomalies in this part of the text. In *Xīn*, *Móhē*, and *Pañc* the sentence structure is fully mirrored. For example, in *Xīn*:

> *sè bù yì kōng, kōng bù yì sè* 色不異空 空不異色
> *sè jí shì kōng, kōng jí shì sè* 色即是空 空即是色
>
> Appearance is not different from absence; absence is not different from appearance. Appearance is just absence, absence is just appearance

28. Compare: *na te duḥkhāt pramokṣo 'sti* (*Udanavārga* 9.4; Bernhard 1965); *yathā duḥkhāt pramucyate* (*Dharmasamuccaya* 3.16; Chaube 1993).

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By contrast, in *Hṛd* the symmetry is lost and the order of the pairs is reversed:

> *rūpaṃ [eva] śūnyatā śūnyataiva rūpaṃ*
> *rūpān na pṛthak śūnyatā śūnyatāyā na pṛthag rūpaṃ*
>
> Appearance is [just] absence, absence is just appearance.
> Appearance is not different from absence; absence is not different from appearance.

In most *Hṛd* manuscripts, the first *eva* is missing. In some *Hṛd* manuscripts, the first phrase is further reduced to *rūpaṃ śūnya* "appearance is empty."[29] Given that *Móhē* has *eva* and *śūnyatā* both times, as do the extant *Pañc* manuscripts and other Chinese translations of the *Large Sutra*, these look like scribal errors.

When we look at the passage in *Pañc* we see the same idea expressed in a different idiom:

> *na hi śāradvatīputrānyad rūpam anyā śunyatā nānyā śunyatānyad rūpam rūpam eva śunyatā śunyataiva rūpam* (Zacchetti 2005, 393)
>
> For, Śāradvatiputra, appearance is not one thing and absence another; absence is not one thing and appearance another; appearance *is* absence, absence *is* appearance.

The phrase *na pṛthak* "not different" is not found in *Pañc* or *Aṣṭa*, where this kind of comparison always involves the idiom: *na anya X anya Y* (Attwood 2017a). It seems that *na pṛthak* in *Hṛd* results from a back translation of *bù yì* 不異 "is not different [from]."

Although the meaning of a term like *rūpa* will seem obvious to most readers, it is routinely mistranslated as "body" or worse "matter" by modern translators of the *Heart Sutra*, and thus we need to look more closely at it. Driven by dissatisfaction with existing translations and explanations, I have elsewhere proposed a revised understanding of the *skandhas* as a process of objectification of experience (Attwood 2022a). In this view, *rūpa* is to the eye as sound is to the ear. *Rūpa* does not refer to what something *is* or what it is *made of*.[30] *Rūpa* is not the object of perception, not "the body," not "matter."[31] Rather it is analogous to *sound*, where sound is the medium through which the object is perceived. *Rūpa* thus means "form" only in

29. The equivalent in Tibetan, *gzugs stong pa*, is also common in Tibetan *Heart Sutra* manuscripts, compare Silk 1994: 176–177.

30. A few Pāli suttas, such as the *Mahāhatthipadopama Sutta* (M 28) remark that *rūpakkhandha* is derived from the four *mahābhūta* (*cattāri ca mahābhūtāni, catunnañca mahābhūtānaṃ upādāya rūpaṃ*. M I 185). The *mahābhūta* "great beings" are the elements of earth, water, heat, and wind (*paṭhavīdhātu*, *āpodhātu*, *tejodhātu*, and *vāyodhātu*). The text goes on to point out that we can experience "earth" with respect to the solid parts of our own body: hair, sinews etc. The four elements are defined phenomenologically in the *Visuddhimagga*: the earth element has the quality of solidity, water the quality of bonding, heat the quality of maturing, wind the quality of supporting (*Yaṃ thaddhalakkhaṇaṃ, ayaṃ pathavīdhātu. Yaṃ ābandhanalakkhaṇaṃ, ayaṃ āpodhātu. Yaṃ paripācanalakkhaṇaṃ, ayaṃ tejodhātu. Yaṃ vitthambhanalakkhaṇaṃ, ayaṃ vāyodhātūti*. Vism 11.27). However, as Ñāṇamoli's (1997, 380, n.19) notes on *Vism* make clear, this is *not* an ontology, this is *a meditation practice*. For example, the solid parts of the body are *where* we look for and find the experience of solidity rather than a definition of the earth element. Here, *paṭhavī* is the experiential common denominator *between* all experiences of solidity rather than the existential category *of* all solid things.

31. Since we can also say that *rūpa* is to the eye as "tangibles" (*spraṣṭavya*) are to the body (*kāya*), *rūpa* cannot have been used to indicate "the body" in this context.

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the sense of how something appears to our eyes. As such, I prefer "appearance" as a general translation. This conclusion is supported by the Chinese translation of *rūpa* as *sè* 色 "outward form, appearance; colour." Likewise, I read *rūpaskandha* as a metonym for the *appearance* of a sensory experience (of any mode) and (re)interpret the *skandhas* accordingly. The appearance (*rūpa*) of a sensory experience has a *valence* (*vedanā*), which is pleasant or unpleasant. We *recognise* and *identify* (*saṃjñā*) the experience (as distinct from the object of experience). There is an opportunity for doing karma (*saṃskāra*). Finally, we distinguish or *discriminate* (*vijñāna*) the object of perception based on the *sui generis* features of our experience of it. In some Buddhist accounts, this then leads to a proliferation (*prapañca*) of conceptualisations and abstractions related to objectified experience. We can think of the *skandhas* as the process by which we objectify our experience and cause ourselves to be trapped in *saṃsāra*, repeatedly undergoing birth and death.

The history of this passage in Prajñāpāramitā literature is complicated because it changed between being stated in *Aṣṭa* and *Pañc* (Attwood 2017b, 55–56). The version found in *Aṣṭa* says:

> *na hi bhagavan anyā sā māyā anyat tad rūpam / rūpam eva bhagavan māyā, māyaiva rūpam* (Vaidya 1960, 8)
>
> Bhagavan, an appearance is not one thing and an illusion another. An Illusion is only an appearance, Bhagavan, an appearance is only an illusion.

It makes a certain kind of sense to say that "an appearance" (*rūpa*) is "an illusion" (*māyā*) or perhaps better "a creation."[32] Knowing the version with *māyā* allows us to relate this passage to similes found in Pāli texts of the type *rūpaṃ māyopamaṃ* "appearance is like an illusion."[33] It appears that Buddhists intended *rūpameva* śūnyatā to be an elaboration of their critique of the hypostatization of sensory experience. This works in (what I take to be) the spirit, if not in the letter, of the expression.

All dharmas

This passage contains one of the most striking and important differences between *Hṛd* and *Pañc*. It was discussed by Nattier (1992, 164–165, 172 and associated notes).

> 舍利子，是諸法空相不生不滅不垢不淨不增不減。
>
> Śāriputra, all dharmas are characterised by absence that does not arise or cease, is not defiled or pure, and is not deficient or growing.
>
> *iha śāriputra sarvadharmāḥ śūnyatālakṣaṇā anutpannā aniruddhā amalā avimalā anūnā aparipūrṇāḥ* |
>
> Here, Śāriputra all dharmas are marked with an absence that does not arise or cease; is not defiled or pure, and is not deficient or complete.

32. While *māyā* is routinely associated in Buddhist texts with the idea of "illusions," in Brahmanical texts it refers to the creative powers of *deva*s. "The gods' *māyā* was associated particularly with the events and seeming marvels of nature, such as the appearance of the sun's bright form at dawn from what previously had been a deep and encompassing darkness or the formation of thunder clouds in an otherwise empty sky" (Mahony 1998, 8). It is surely in this sense, for example, that the word was used in the name Māyā Gautamī.

33. Notably in the *Pheṇapiṇḍūpama Sutta* (S 22.95).

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Here *Hṛd* appears to follow *Xīn* quite well. However, when we go back to *Pañc*, we see how *Hṛd* is substantially different. The same passage in the Gilgit manuscript of *Pañc* reads:

> *yā Śāradvatīputra śūnyatā na sā utpadyate, no nirudhyate na saṃkliśyate, na vyavadāyate, na hīyate, na vardhate.* (Zacchetti 2005, 393)
>
> That absence, Śāradvatīputra, is not subject to arising, ceasing, defiling, purifying, declining, or growing.

There are three main differences here:

1. In *Pañc*, the subject is *śūnyatā*, while in *Hṛd* it is *sarvadharmāḥ*.
2. In *Pañc*, the attributes of *śūnyatā* are expressed as the absence of activities, using finite verbs in the passive voice, third-person singular indicative.[34] In *Hṛd* the attributes of all dharmas are adjectives (necessarily in the plural).
3. In *Pañc*, the terms used are common and idiomatic, while in *Hṛd* they are mostly uncommon and unidiomatic.

As Nattier (1992, 205, n.26) remarks, "In this context, without an explicit subject in the Chinese text [of *Xīn*], the reader would most naturally assume that the subject is 'all dharmas' [*zhū fǎ* 諸法]—which is exactly what we find in the Sanskrit *Heart Sūtra*." However, it is also possible to read *Xīn* as consistent with *Pañc*, that is, "all dharmas are marked with *an absence that* is not subject to arising, ceasing, etc." Here, absence (*śūnyatā*, *kōng* 空) is not subject to arising because it is the state that occurs when all conditions for sensory experience are absent (due to practising non-apprehension: see Section 2.4 below). Nor does absence cease (in the conventional Buddhist sense) since there is no existing condition in place, the removal of which would cause absence to cease. Still, in *Pañc* there is no mention of dharmas in this context. Again this is consistent with the core passage of *Hṛd* being a back-translation of the same passage in *Pañc* via a Chinese intermediary (specifically, *Móhē*).

Nidānas and negation

> 是故空中無色無受想行識，無眼耳鼻舌身意，無色聲香味觸法，無眼界乃至無意識界，無無明亦無無明盡乃至無老死亦無老死盡，無苦集滅道，無得無現觀，以無所得故。
>
> In the state of absence—there is no appearance, valence, recognition, volitions, or discrimination; no eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, or mental sense; no appearance, sound, smell, taste, touch, or mental phenomena; no eye-sphere etc up to no mental cognition sphere; no ignorance or cessation of ignorance etc up to no ageing and death or the cessation of ageing and death; no dissatisfaction, no origin, no cessation, no path; no attainment and no realisation—through the practice of non-apprehension.
>
> *tasmāc chāriputra śūnyatāyāṃ na rūpaṃ na vedanā na saṃjñā na saṃskārāḥ na vijñāna, na caksuḥ-śrotra-ghrāṇa-jihvā-kāya-manāṃsi na rūpa-śabda-gandha-rasa-spraṣṭavya-*

34. In both the Gilgit Manuscript and the Nepalese edition of *Pañc*, *vardhate* is in the active voice.

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dharmāḥ na cakṣurdhātur yāvan na manovijñānadhātuḥ nāvidyā nāvidyākṣayo yāvan na jarāmaraṇaṃ na jarāmaraṇakṣayo na duḥkha-samudaya-nirodha-mārgā na jñānam na prāptiḥ ||

In the state of absence—there is no appearance, valence, recognition, volitions, or discrimination; no eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, or mental sense; no appearance, sound, smell, taste, touch, or mental phenomena; no eye-sphere etc up to no mental cognition sphere; no ignorance or cessation of ignorance etc up to no ageing and death or the cessation of ageing and death; no dissatisfaction, no origin, no cessation, no path; no attainment and no realisation.

This section contains the negated lists of *skandhas*, *āyatanas*, *dhātus*, *nidānas*, *āryasatyas*, and *āryapudgalas*, that is, the basic categories used in a Buddhist analysis of experience.[35] It is sometimes suggested that these lists come from Abhidharma, but they predate the Abhidharma movements and are found, for example, in many Pāli suttas.[36] Here, I will focus on the *nidānas* or the links of dependent arising (*pratītyasamutpāda*):

無無明亦無無明盡 乃至　無老死亦無老死盡

Wú wúmíng yì wú wúmíng jǐn nǎizhì wú lǎosǐ yì wú lǎosǐ jǐn
nāvidyā nāvidyākṣayo yāvan na jarāmaraṇaṃ na jarāmaraṇakṣayo

This is an odd way of stating the *nidānas* in their forward (*anuloma*) and reverse (*pratiloma*) directions simultaneously, but this is what it is. The first *nidāna* is *wúmíng* 無明 "ignorance" (*avidyā*) and the last is *lǎosǐ* 老死 "ageing and death" (*jarāmaraṇa*). In the forward direction, ignorance is the condition for volitions, volitions are the condition for discrimination and so on up to (*nǎizhì* 乃至; *yāvan*) birth is the condition for ageing and death. In the reverse direction, the cessation of birth is the cessation of death, and so on down to the cessation of ignorance is the cessation of volition.

In *Pañc*, the *nidānas* are spelt out, beginning with *nāvidyotpādo nāvidyānirodhaḥ* "[In the absence of sensory experience] there is no arising of ignorance, no ceasing of ignorance" and ending with *na jarāmaraṇaśokaparidevaduḥkhadaurmanasyopāyās otpādo na jarāmaraṇaśokaparidevaduḥkhadaurmanasyopāyāsanirodhaḥ* or "No arising of ageing, death, sorrow, lamenting, misery, dejection, and trouble, [and] no cessation of ageing, death, sorrow, lamenting, misery, dejection, and trouble" (Kimura 1986–2007, I–1, 64). The last *nidāna* is ageing and death, and the phrase *śokaparideva duḥkhadaurmanasyopāyāsotpādo* is usually added as a kind of summary, for example,

35. Note that the extant texts of *Pañc* spell out the *āyatanas* and *dhātus* in full, and negate each one individually: *na cakṣurāyatanaṃ na rūpāyatanaṃ na śrotrāyatanaṃna śabdāyatanaṃ na ghrāṇāyatanaṃ na gandhāyatanaṃ na jihvāyatanaṃ rasāyatanaṃ na kāyāyatanaṃ spraṣṭavyāyatanaṃ na manaāyatanaṃ dharmāyatanam, na cakṣurdhātur na rūpadhātur na cakṣurvijñānadhātuḥ, na śrotradhātur na śabdadhātur na śrotravijñānadhātuḥ, na ghrāṇadhātur na gandhadhātur na ghrāṇavijñānadhātuḥ, na jihvādhātur na rasadhātur na jihvāvijñānadhātuḥ, na kāyadhātur na spraṣṭavyadhātur na kāyavijñānadhātuḥ na manodhātur na dharmadhātur na manovijñānadhātuḥ*, (Kimura 1986–2007, I-1 65; the Gilgit manuscript leaves off the word –āyatana but is otherwise the same; Zacchetti 2005, 393).

36. Most have whole chapters devoted to them in the *Saṃyutta Nikāya*. See for example the *khandhasaṃyutta* (Chap 22), *Saḷāyātanasaṃyutta* (Chap 35), *Nidānasaṃyutta* (Cpt 12), *Dhātusaṃyutta* (Chap 14), and the *Saccasaṃyutta* (Chap 56).

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in the Pāli expression: "This is the source of sorrow, lamenting, misery, dejection, and trouble. This is the arising of this whole mass of misery."[37]

In the Hōryūji manuscript, which is one of the oldest extant witnesses of *Hṛd*,[38] we see two phrases interpolated into the text so that it becomes:

> *na vidyā nāvidyā na vidyākṣayo nāvidyāksāyo yāvan na jarāmaraṇaṃ na jarāmaraṇakṣayo.*
>
> No knowledge, no ignorance, no end of knowledge, no end of ignorance, up to, no ageing and death and no end of ageing and death.

The redactor who inserted *na vidyā* "no knowledge" and *na vidyākṣayo* "no destruction of knowledge" was evidently unfamiliar with this approach to the *nidāna*s and interpreted the text as being concerned with simple negation. As a result, they have turned an unusual expression of the *nidāna* list into something nonsensical.

The *nidāna* section of *Hṛd* also gives us one of the most straightforward examples of a back-translation. The usual expression for the "cessation of ignorance" in the *nidāna* context is *avidyānirodha* (Pāli *avijjānirodha*). Instead, *Hṛd* has the unique expression *avidyākṣaya*, where *kṣaya* is a synonym of *nirodha* meaning "loss, decline, destruction, etc." The expression *avidyākṣaya* is found in no other text of any kind, except for commentaries on the *Heart Sutra*. Therefore, it was not copied from any existing Sanskrit text, let alone a Sanskrit Prajñāpāramitā text. The expression in *Xīn* is *wúmíng jǐn* 無明盡 which also means "the destruction of ignorance." This was copied from Kumārajīva's translation of the *Large Sutra*, but it is an oddity since his usual translation of *nirodha* is *miè* 滅. For example, in the four noble truths—*kǔ jí miè dào* 苦集滅道 "*duḥkha*, *samudaya*, *nirodha*, *mārga,*" which immediately follow the *nidānas*. *Avidyākṣaya* appears to be a back-translation of *wúmíng jǐn* 無明盡.[39]

Nonattainment or non-apprehension?

> 無得無現觀，以無所得故。
>
> There is no attainment and no realisation, through the practice of non-apprehension.
>
> *na jñānam na prāptiḥ | aprāptitvād...*
>
> No knowledge and no attainment. Because of the lack of attainment...

The penultimate phrase of the core section in the revised Chinese edition is *wú dé wú xiàn guān* 無得無現觀 (drawn from Xuánzàng's translation of *Pañc*, T220–2 [7] 14a23). Huifeng (2014, 85 and 89–91) showed that this better reflects the *Pañc* text—*na prāptir nābhisamayaḥ* "no attainment, no realisation"—than either the canonical

37. *...sokaparidevadukkhadomanassupāyāsā sambhavanti. Evametassa kevalassa dukkhakkhandhassa samudayo hoti.* This pericope occurs many times, for example, D II 33.

38. This manuscript is now thought to have been copied in the ninth or tenth century (Silk 2021). The Sanskrit text in T256, transcribed using Chinese characters, is now associated with Amoghavajra (d. 774CE).

39. The term *kṣaya* is used in the term *āsravakṣaya* "the destruction of the influxes." This term appears to have evolved from an earlier, possibly Jain, theory of karma, in which actions cause an influx (*āsrava*) of substance (*dravya*) that weighs down the soul (*jīva*) causing it to undergo rebirth. The state of āsravakṣaya is consistent with no longer creating karma, and thus escape from *saṃsāra*. In other words, it is equivalent to enlightenment.

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text of *Xīn* (*wú zhì yì wú dé* 無智亦無得) or the received *Hṛd* text (*na jñānaṃ na prāptiḥ*), both of which translate as "no knowledge and no attainment." I have elsewhere shown that the two terms *prāpti* and *abhisamaya* correspond to the more familiar *mārga* "path" and *phala* "fruit" in the familiar list of the eight *āryapudgala*, that is, the attainment (*prāpti*) of the path and realisation (*abhisamaya*) of the fruit of the stream-entrant, once-returner, non-returner, and arahant (Attwood 2020a, 19–20). To this traditional list, *Pañc* adds the attainments and realisations of the bodhisatva, *pratyekabuddha*, and buddha, making fourteen in total (Zacchetti 2005, 393; Kimura 1986–2007, I–1 65). This phrase, then, is not a general negation of knowledge (*jñāna*) or attainment (*prāpti*), which remain central to Buddhist soteriology. Rather, it completes the standard list of Buddhist analytical categories.

In the revised *Xīn* the negated lists are qualified at the beginning by *kōng zhōng* 空中 "in emptiness" and at the end by *yǐwúsuǒdégù* 以無所得故 "by the practice of non-apprehension" (c.f. Huifeng 2014, 80, 86–89, Attwood 2021b, 32–34). Here, non-apprehension is the method by which one attains a state of emptiness; the state in which no dharmas are arising or ceasing. That is to say, the *Heart Sutra* is not asserting that "dharmas do not exist." It is asserting that when all dharmas have ceased—due to practising non-apprehension of dharmas—no dharmas are known, perceived, or apprehended.

Huifeng (2014) showed that *yǐwúsuǒdégù* 以無所得故 was mistranslated in *Hṛd* as *aprāptitvāt* "from nonattainment," a word that does not occur in *Pañc* (even *aprāpti* appears to be used just once: Kimura 1986–2007, II–III, 160). This (mistaken) sense was read back into *Xīn*, and interpreted as belonging with what follows (that is, the bodhisatva being reliant on *prajñāpāramitā*) whereas based on *Pañc* and *Xīn* we expect the term to qualify (and thus *go with*) the negated lists. Kumārajīva coined the term *yǐwúsuǒdégù* 以無所得故 to translate *anupalambhayogena* "by means of practising non-apprehension" or the phrase *tac cānupalambhayogena* "And that by means of the practice of non-apprehension." Elsewhere, I have shown these terms are typically used in the final position of a passage to qualify what has come before (Attwood 2020a). For example:

> *evaṃ śikṣamāṇaḥ śāriputra bodhisattvo mahāsattvaḥ prajñāpāramitāyāṃ śikṣate, anupalambhayogena. evaṃ dhyānapāramitāyāṃ vīryapāramitāyāṃ kṣāntipāramitāyāṃ śīlapāramitāyāṃ dānapāramitāyāṃ śikṣate, anupalambhayogena.* (Kimura 1986–2007, I-1 187)

> Śāriputra, training in this way, a *bodhisatva mahāsatva* trains in *prajñāpāramitā*, by means of practising non-apprehension. He trains in the perfection of mediation, energy, forbearance, ethics, and generosity by means of non-apprehension.

There are many similar examples, particularly in the passages corresponding to Chapter Sixteen in Conze's (1975, 153) translation of *Pañc* (the Sanskrit text begins at Kimura I-2, 75).[40]

40. Compare also the brief discussion of *anupalambhayogena* amidst other issues in Schlosser (2022, 229–240). I thank Chris Jones for drawing my attention also to Steinkellner (1992).

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Without far-reaching changes to the text, there is no way to make the core section of *Hṛd* reflect the sense of the core section in *Xīn*. This will become clearer in the discussion of section 3.1, to which we can now turn.

Praise

Relying on Prajñāpāramitā

菩提薩埵依般若波羅蜜多故心無罣礙，無罣礙故無有恐怖遠離顛倒夢想究竟涅槃。

Since the bodhisatva relies on perfect insight their mind is not attached anywhere; being detached they are not afraid, transcend illusions and delusions, and attain final extinction.

tasmāc chāriputra aprāptitvād bodhisatvaḥ prajñāpāramitām āśritya viharaty acittāvaraṇaś cittāvaraṇanāstitvād atrasto viparyāsātikrānto niṣṭhānirvāṇaḥ |

Therefore, *Śāriputra*, because of being in a state of non-attainment, the bodhisatva who is without mental hindrance dwells having relied on perfect insight, from the nonexistence of mental hindrance [he] is not afraid, transcends delusions, and his extinction is complete.

Something seems to have gone drastically wrong with the back-translation here. The first clause of the passage in *Xīn* is relatively simple: *Pútísàduǒ yī bānrěbōluómìduō gù* 菩提薩埵依般若波羅蜜多故, that is, "Since (*gù* 故 in clause-final position) the bodhisatva (*pútísàduǒ* 菩提薩埵) relies on (*yī* 依) perfected insight (*bānrěbōluómìduō* 般若波羅蜜多)...". This is followed by the expected consequence of such reliance, *xīn wú guà'ài* 心無罣礙. Here *xīn* 心 corresponds to *citta*, meaning something like "mental activity," since it includes thoughts, emotions, and memories. The term *wú guà'ài* 無罣礙 begins with *wú* 無, a negating particle. Two verbs follow: *guà* 罣 "ensnare" and ài 礙 "impede." Again, the two characters appear to be either a binomial or a double translation. Huifeng (2014, 92–96) showed that Kumārajīva translated the verb *sajjati* "stick, adhere" as *guà'ài* 罣礙 and that *wú guà'ài* 無罣礙 typically reflects the Sanskrit phrase *na kvacit sajjati* "not stuck anywhere" or "not adhering to anything." Here *Hṛd* has *viharaty acittāvaraṇa* "[he] dwells without mental hindrance," a non-idiomatic synonym reflective of a back-translation, which Conze (1958, 93) further obscures in his English translation: "[he] dwells without thought coverings."[41] The first two phrases in *Xīn* read:

菩提薩埵依般若波羅蜜多故心無罣礙

Since he relies on perfected insight, his mind is not stuck anywhere...

This makes good sense in a Buddhist context. The next phrase runs on: *wú guà'ài gù* 無罣礙故, "since (*gù* 故) [he is] unattached (*wú guà'ài* 無罣礙)", and the final part informs us of the consequences of his nonattachment: "he is unafraid (*wú yǒu kǒngbù* 無有恐怖), removed from illusions and delusions (*yuǎnlí diāndǎo mèngxiǎng* 遠離顛倒夢想), and his extinction is complete (*jiùjìng nièpán* 究竟涅槃)." The *bodhisatva* is

41. Note also Conze's use of the plural here when his own Sanskrit text is clearly in the singular.

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"unattached" or "detached" precisely because they are withholding attention from sensory experience, causing it to cease (for them).

Hṛd only dimly reflects *Xīn* at this point and can barely be understood as a translation. For *yì* 依 "reliance" we would expect *ni√śri* "to lean on or against; to rely on" but the back-translator opts for the almost synonymous *ā√śri* "to affix, to apply; to depend on" and chooses the absolutive form *āśritya*. The next phrase is especially confused in *Hṛd*. The Chinese *xīn wú guà'ai* 心無罣礙 "his mind is unattached" becomes *viharaty acittāvaraṇaḥ* "he dwells without a mental hindrance." *Hṛd* then tries to convey *wú guà'ài gù* 無罣礙故 "since he is unattached" using the phrase *cittāvaraṇanāstitvāt* "because of the state of nonexistence of mental obstruction." While the expression *nāstitvāt* "because of the state of nonexistence" is not unknown in Sanskrit,[42] *cittāvaraṇanāstitvāt* is a convoluted way of getting this idea across. The simplest approach to this would have been to use an adverbial pronoun, such as *tena* or *tasmāt*. For example, in Sanskrit we might have phrased it as, *cittas tasya na kvacit sajjati, tena...* "his mind does not adhere anywhere, therefore...". This would be far more in keeping with the idiom of Buddhist texts. *Tasmāt* is used this way elsewhere in *Hṛd*.

In *Hṛd*, the consequences of detachment have been back-translated as a series of adjectival compounds: *atrastaḥ, viparyāsātikrāntaḥ*, and *niṣṭhānirvāṇaḥ*.[43] The second adjective in *Hṛd* omits reference to "illusions" (*mèngxiǎng* 夢想; *māyā*), and mistakenly back-translates *yuǎnlí* 遠離 "removed from, isolated" by the past participle *atikrānta* "transcended" when something like *vivikta* "separated, isolated" would have been more appropriate and salient. Moreover, *atikranta* is ambiguous because it can also mean "transgressed,",whereas the more idiomatic, less equivocal, choice from the root √*kram* would have been *samatikranta* "transcended."

The relationship between the *Xīn* and *Hṛd* versions of this passage could hardly be more tenuous, and the word choices in the back-translation less helpful. A straightforward, if not simple, Chinese sentence in *Xīn* has become convoluted and barely coherent in *Hṛd*. After this extreme divergence, the texts converge again in the next passage.

The buddhas of the three times

三世諸佛 依 般若波羅蜜多故 得阿耨多羅三藐三菩提。

The buddhas of the three times, depending on perfect insight, attained full and perfect awakening.

42. The term occurs in Kumārila Bhaṭṭa's *Mīmāṃsaślokavārttika* (5, 7.35). https://gretil.sub.uni-goettingen.de/gretil/corpustei/transformations/ html/sa_kumArila-mImAMsazlokavArttika-comm.htm. Accessed August 21, 2021. I have not found it in any Buddhist text.

43. In Conze's (1948; 1967) edition of *Hṛd*, these adjectives are isolated from the noun they describe (*bodhisattvaḥ*) by an erroneous full stop (Attwood 2018a, 15), making a "sentence" with no subject and no verb. This mistake continues to go unnoticed by editors and translators alike. In Conze's first edition (1948, 36) and his popular text, translation, and commentary (1958, 93), the word *bodhisatva* is in the genitive singular case (*bodhisattvasya*) which further obscures the relationship with these adjectives, though this is corrected in the revised edition (1967, 152), it persists in the reprints of the popular text (1958).

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> *Tryadhvavyavasthitāḥ sarvabuddhāḥ prajñāpāramitām āśritya anuttarāṃ samyaksambodhim abhisambuddhāḥ* |
>
> Having relied on perfect insight, all the buddhas appearing in the three times fully awaken to the unexcelled perfectly complete awakening.

Given the difficulties encountered in *Hṛd* 3.1, *Hṛd* 3.2 turns out to be relatively straightforward. Attwood (2018b, 19-22) showed that *tryadhvavyavasthitāḥ sarvabuddhāḥ* is a calque of *sānshì zhū fó* 三世諸佛 "buddhas of the three times." Sanskrit Prajñāpāramitā literature has a strong preference for the unabbreviated "buddhas of the past, future, and present" (*atītānāgatapratyutpannā buddhāḥ*) usually (though not always) without *sarva* since citing "buddhas" in the plural and "of the three times" both imply "all buddhas." The *vyavasthita* "appearing" is also redundant and is not used in this way in Sanskrit Prajñāpāramitā literature. The abbreviated term *sānshì* zhū fó 三世諸佛 "buddhas of the three times" was introduced by Chinese translators in the mid-third Century CE (Attwood 2018b, 14), but it did not wholly supplant the unabbreviated form: *guòqù wèilái xiànzài zhū fó* 過去未來現在諸佛, with semantic loan words for past (*guòqù* 過去), future (*wèilái* 未來), and present (*xiànzài* 現在).

The gist of this passage is that Prajñāpāramitā is the basis on which one becomes a buddha. We might be tempted to dismiss such claims as Buddhist exceptionalism; as just another case of a Buddhist text claiming to be the "ultimate teaching."[44] Anālayo (2015, 75–169), Huifeng (2016, 118–127), and Attwood (2022a, 126–129) have all independently speculated that the meditation described in the *Cūḷāsuññata Sutta* is (at least conceptually) connected with *anupalambhayoga* "the practice of nonapprehension." *Cūḷasuññata Sutta* (M 121) explains how *suññatāvihāra* "dwelling in emptiness" is achieved through *amanasikāra* "inattention [to sensory experience]," resulting in "stages" (*āyatana*) of reduced sensory experience, and culminating in the [complete] "absence of sensory experience" (*suññatā*).

Superlatives

> 故知般若波羅蜜多是大明呪無上明呪無等等明呪。能除一切苦真實不虛。
>
> Know that perfect insight is great expertise, unexcelled expertise, and unequalled expertise. It can remove all suffering; it is true and not false.
>
> *tasmāj jñātavyam prajñāpāramitā mahāmantro 'nuttaramantro 'samasamamantraḥ sarvaduḥkhapraśamanas satyam amithyatvāt* |
>
> Therefore, know that perfect insight is a great spell, a great spell of mastery, an unexcelled spell, an unequalled spell that allays all suffering and it is true because it is not wrongness.

Great, unexcelled, and unequalled

Traditionally, the *Heart Sutra* is said to contain a mantra. However, the most commonly cited dates for the composition of the text predate the use of mantras by

44. It is interesting to note that these techniques of nonattention (Pāli *amanasikāra*) to, or nonapprehension (Skt. *anupalambhayoga*) of, sensory experience may well antedate Buddhism. Compare remarks by Anālayo (2022, 1673).

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Buddhists by some centuries meaning that this is an anachronism.[45] In this passage, the terms "great, unexcelled, and unequalled" have been considered to be "epithets of the mantra," though examination of the context shows that the epithets are applied to Prajñāpāramitā per se, rather than the "mantra."

Based on unpublished remarks by Yamabe Nobuyoshi, Nattier (1992, 211–213, n. 54a) noted that where *Hṛd* has *mantra*, *Pañc* appeared to have *vidyā*. Taking this further, Attwood (2017b) showed the epithets passage occurs twice in *Aṣṭa* and *Pañc* and their numerous Chinese translations. All of the extant Sanskrit texts have *vidyā* and it appears that all of the Chinese texts were translating *vidyā.* Notably, Kumārajīva's *Móhē* has:

> 般若波羅蜜是大明呪、無上明呪、無等等明呪。(T223 [8] 286b28)
>
> Perfect insight is a great *vidyā*, an unexcelled *vidyā*, an unequalled *vidyā.*

In Kumārajīva's translation lexicon, *míngzhòu* 明呪 translates *vidyā*. Since *zhòu* 呪 means "incantation" we know that Kumārajīva must have understood *vidyā* not only as a kind of expert knowledge but also as a kind of "mastery" expressed in formulaic verbal form. Medieval Buddhists believed such formulas to have magical powers. By contrast, in 286 CE, Mokṣala (T221 [8] 48b14–22) translated *vidyā* in this context as *shù* 術 "technique, art, or skill," which may be closer to the intentions of the author(s) of the *Aṣṭasāhasrikā.*

The superlatives in *Xīn* were copied from *Móhē* but changed, seemingly to better reflect Xuánzàng's translation lexicon:

> 故知般若波羅蜜多，是大神咒，是大明咒，是無上咒，是無等等咒。
>
> Know that perfect insight is a great expertise, a great expertise, unexcelled expertise, and unequalled expertise.

Note here that 咒 and 呪 are graphical variants of the same character. Samuel Beal (1865), with no knowledge of the Sanskrit text, and relying on a Tang Dynasty commentary, read *zhòu* 呪 as *dhāraṇī*. As we see, *míngzhòu* 明呪 "*vidyā*" in *Móhē* becomes simply *zhòu* 呪 "incantation" in *Xīn*. Translators of *Xīn* have tended to read *míngzhòu* 明呪 as two characters, with poor results such as "illuminated incantation" (West 2000, 117), "clarity charm" (Hurvitz 1977, 112), or "enlightening zhou" (Mattice 2021, 217). I have shown (Attwood 2017b, 31) that *dà shén zhòu* 大神咒 is another spelling of *mahāvidyā* and is omitted from my revised Chinese text, which restores the reading from *Móhē*:

> 故知般若波羅蜜多是大明呪無上明呪無等等明呪。
>
> Know that perfect insight is great expertise, unexcelled expertise, and unequalled expertise.

45. When Tantric Buddhism begins is moot, but Hodge (2003, 9) notes that Xuánzàng (travelling in Indian ca 629-645 CE) does not mention any form of Tantric Buddhism in his travelogue, whereas Yìjìng 義淨who arrived in India in 683 CE does mention Tantric Buddhism. Hodge (2003, 11) dates the composition of the first, fully Tantric Buddhist text, the *Mahāvairocana Abhisaṃbodhi Tantra*, to ca 640.

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In the revised edition of *Hṛd* (Attwood forthcoming) the line has become:

> *tasmāj jñātavyam prajñāpāramitā mahā-mantro 'nuttara-mantro 'samasama-mantraḥ sarva-duḥkha-praśamanaḥ, satyam amithyatvāt.*
>
> Therefore, know that perfect insight is a great spell, a great spell of mastery, an unexcelled spell, an unequalled spell that allays all suffering and it is true because it is not wrongness.

This edition omits *mahāvidyāmantraḥ* on the grounds that it is omitted in both *Móhē* and *Pañc*. The three standard epithets in *Móhē* correspond to those in *Pañc*.

dàmíngzhòu	大明呪	*mahāvidyā*
wú shàng míngzhòu	無上明呪	*anuttarā vidyā*
wú děngděng míngzhòu	無等等明呪	*asamasamā vidyā*

Xuánzàng's translations of *Pañc* are odd for having five superlatives, adding *dàshénzhòu* 大神呪 and *yīqiè zhòu wáng* 一切呪王 "queen of all *vidyās*" (**sarvavidyārājñī*) to the usual three. However, the same passage in the Gilgit *Pañc* manuscript reads:

> *mahāvidyeyaṃ bhagavan yaduta prajñāpāramitā | anuttareyaṃ bhagavan vidyā yaduta prajñāpāramitā* [13] *asamasameyaṃ bhagavan vidyā yaduta prajñāpāramitā* | (Karashima *et al.* 2016, folio 146v. lines 12–13; my transcription)
>
> Bhagavan, that perfection of insight is a great expertise. Bhagavan, that perfection of insight is an unexcelled expertise. Bhagavan, that perfection of insight is an unequalled expertise.

The version of *Pañc* in Kimura (1986–2007, II–III, 70) substantially agrees.[46] Although *mantra* and *vidyā* (along with *dhāraṇī*) overlap in meaning amongst tantric Buddhists, the same cannot be said for *Aṣṭa* or *Pañc*. Mantra is mentioned just three times in *Aṣṭa* with only one parallel in *Pañc*.[47] From these references, we can infer

46. *evam etat kauśikaivam etat, mahāvidyeyaṃ kauśika yad uta prajñāpāramitā, anuttareyaṃ kauśika vidyā yad uta prajñāpāramitā, asamasameyaṃ kauśika vidyā yad uta prajñāpāramitā.*

47. 1) *teṣu ca susthitāḥ samāhitāśca bhaviṣyanti asyāṃ prajñāpāramitāyām | māreṇāpi te na śakyā bhedayitum, kutaḥ punar anyaiḥ sattvaiḥ, yad utac chandato vā mantrato vā* (Vaidya 1960, 113); The counterpart passage in Kumārajīva's *Xiǎopǐnbōrě jīng* «小品般若經» begins at T227 (8) 555b6, but there is no mention of mantra.

    2) *sa yānīmāni strīṇāṃ vaśīkaraṇāni mantra-jāpyauṣadhi-vidyā-bhaiṣajyādīni, tāni sarvāṇi sarveṇa sarvaṃ na prayojayati* | (Vaidya 1960, 166) which corresponds to: 阿惟越致菩薩，執金剛神常隨侍衛，不令非人近之。... 不以呪術藥草引接女人。(T227 [8] 565a24). Compare *Pañc*: *punar aparaṃ subhūte bodhisattvo mahāsattvo bodhimanasikāraiḥ samanvāgato yāni tāni strīṇām āveśanāni vaśīkaraṇāni mantravidyauṣadhibhaiṣajyāni tāni sarvāṇi sarveṇa sarvaṃ sarvathā sarvan na prayukte na ca prayojayati na ca strīṇām āveśanam anyatarānyataraṃ karoti, na striyāḥ puruṣasya vā ādeśanāprātihāryaṃ karoti, putro vā te bhaviṣyati dhītā vā te bhaviṣyati, kulodgato vā bhaviṣyati, dīrghāyuṣko vā bhaviṣyati.* (Kimura 1986–2007, IV 157).

    3) *yatra sattvāḥ kalāsu kovidāḥ, kāvyeṣu kovidāḥ, mantreṣu kovidāḥ, vidyāsu kovidāḥ, śāstreṣu kovidāḥ, nimitteṣu kovidāḥ, dharmārthakovidāḥ* / (Vaidya 1960, 167) and the Chinese parallel: 須菩提！阿惟越致菩薩，多於欲界、色界命終來生中國，善於伎藝，明解經書， 呪術占相，悉能了知。 (T227 [8] 565b11-15).

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that mantra played no part in the bodhisatva path known to the authors of *Aṣṭa* or *Pañc*.[48]

The incantation at the end of the *Heart Sutra* was most likely copied from the *Tuóluóní jí jīng* «陀羅尼集經» (T901 [18] 807.b19-26) "Dhāraṇī Collection." The *Heart Sutra* incantation lacks the diagnostic features and tantric context of a mantra and has many features of a *dhāraṇī*; I conclude that it *is* a *dhāraṇī* (Attwood 2017b). On investigation, there is no obvious connection between the *dhāraṇī* at the end of the text and the passage that states that Prajñāpāramitā is a "great *vidyā*, the ultimate *vidyā*, an unequalled *vidyā*."

Removing suffering

能除一切苦
néng chú yīqiè kǔ
It can remove all suffering
sarvaduḥkhapraśamanaḥ
allays all suffering

The subject of this sentence is *Prajñāpāramitā* qua superlative *vidyā*. The *Dàmíngzhòu jīng* has the same text as *Xīn* (T250 [8] 847c25). However, this precise phrase does not occur at all in the extant *Móhē*. Kumārajīva uses *néng chú* 能除 to translate several Sanskrit verbs, including *parihīyante*,[49] *śodhayati*,[50] and *vivarjita*.[51] In these examples, Kumārajīva uses *néng* 能 "capable of, able to" when the extant Sanskrit manuscripts have nothing corresponding to this term, so its presence in *Xīn* could be purely conventional. *Hṛd* translates *néng chú yīqiè kǔ* 能除一切苦 as *sarvaduḥkhapraśamanaḥ*, which also does not translate *néng* 能 as a distinct term. Xuánzàng does not use *néng chú yīqiè kǔ* 能除一切苦 in his anthology of Prajñāpāramitā (T220), though he does use the phrase *néng chú yīqiè* 能除一切 "it can remove all X" in several other contexts.[52]

Several of Conze's (1948, 37, n.56) manuscripts have *sarvaduḥkhapraśamano mantraḥ* or *sarvaduḥkhapraśamanamantraḥ*.[53] While *Pañc* does not use *praśamana* in

48. A further mention of "protecting the secret mantras" (*guhyamantrarakṣaṇāc*) in *Pañc* (Kimura 1986–2007, VI–VIII 63) is not found in *Aṣṭa*. This tantric concept postdates the original composition of the Prajñāpāramitā texts by some centuries and may be considered a later interpolation.

49. 是般若波羅蜜能除一切不善，能與一切善法。(T223 [8] 286c1-2) = *prajñāpāramitāyā mārṣā udgrahītayā dhāritayā vācitayā paryavāptayā sarve 'kuśalā dharmāḥ parihīyante kuśalā dharmā vivardhante* (Kimura 1986–2007 II-III, 69).

50. 舍利弗白佛言：「世尊！菩薩摩訶薩云何除身、口、意麤業？」佛告舍利弗：「若菩薩摩訶薩不得身、口、意，如是菩薩摩訶薩能除身、口、意麤業。(T223 [8] 226c24-26) = *śāriputra āha: kathaṃ bhagavan bodhisattvo mahāsattvaḥ kāyavāṅmanodauṣṭhulyaṃ śodhayati? bhagavān āha: yataḥ śāriputra bodhisattvo mahāsattvo na kāyam upalabhate, na vācam upalabhate, na mana upalabhate. evaṃ hi śāriputra bodhisattvo mahāsattvaḥ kāyavāṅmanodauṣṭhulyaṃ śodhayati,* (Kimura 1986–2007, I–1 89)

51. 須菩提！是十二因緣是獨菩薩法，能除諸邊顛倒，(T223 [8] 364b23-24) = *iyaṃ subhūte bodhisattvasya mahāsattvasya pratītyasamutpādavyavalokanā ādyantavivarjitā*, (Kimura 1986–2007, V 80)

52. For example: 如是般若波羅蜜多，能除一切惡不善法 (T220 [5] 580c2–3).

53. Conze (1948, 37) suggests that manuscripts N^a, N^c, N^d, N^e, C^a, C^g and J^b have *sarva-duḥkha-*

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relation to *sarvaduḥkha*,[54] the concept of "pacifying suffering" is found, for example: "Having pacified the sufferings of beings in Hell" (*nairayikānāṃ sattvānāṃ duḥkhāni praśāmya* Kimura 1986-2007, I-2 46). This phrase is followed by a pair of terms.

True and not false

真實不虛

It is true and not false.

satyam amithyatvāt [55]

It is truth because it is not wrongness.

I have elsewhere noted that the Sanskrit expression *satyam amithyatvāt* appears to mix up two pairs, that is, *satya/mṛṣā* and *samyañc/mithyā* (Attwood 2021b, 43–45). In Buddhist Sanskrit, "truth" (*satya*) is "not false" or "without falsehood" (*na mṛṣā, amṛṣā*) and vice versa.[56] A similar relation applies to the other pair: that which is *samyañc* "consistent [with reality]" is *amithyā* "not inconsistent."

Here the Chinese *zhēnshí* 真實 has been used to translate a range of terms related to ideas of "truth" and "reality" (especially *bhūta*, *tathatva*, *tattva*),[57] while *xū* 虛 is used for a variety of words for the opposite (for example, *mṛṣā*, *mithyā*, *abhūta*).[58] The back-translator had a choice but seemingly overlooked the context of how these terms are used in relation to each other. This is also an example of the back-translator's habit of turning an adjective into an abstract noun in the ablative case. The Chinese text seems to suggest that "[*prajñāpāramitā*] is true and not false" (真實不虛). In Sanskrit we might expect: **satyā amṛṣā ca* or perhaps **bhutā ca nābhutā ca*). What we find is the awkward phrase: *satyam amithyatvāt* "it is true because it is in a state of non-inconsistency."

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praśamano mantraḥ. He has incorrectly recorded some variant readings, that is, J^b: *sarvaduḥkhapraśamanamantraḥ*; C^g: *sarvaduḥkhaprasama[na]mantra* (*na* omitted). In Feer's (1866) polyglot edition, reprinted in Milloué (1885), the standard text (= Conze ms. C^e. 1948, 49) has *sarvadūḥkhapraśamaṇaḥ*, however the extended text in Milloué (1885, 194) omits this phrase, which Conze does not notice.

54. The word occurs just once in the text of Kimura's edition in the opening description of the bodhisatvas present at the preaching of *Pañc* (*nānādṛṣṭy-anuśayaparyavasthānakleśa-praśamanakuśalaiḥ* 1986–2007, I–1, 1). The Gilgit manuscript has a slightly different compound here: *nānādṛṣṭi-paryutthānasatvakleśa-praśamanakuśalaiḥ* (Zacchetti 2005, 366). It is not clear to me which is the better reading.

55. Conze (1948, 37) notes that manuscripts he labels C^a and C^e have *saṃyaktvaṃ na mithyatvaṃ*. Conze cites the manuscript he labels C^a as "Printed in M. Müller, pp. 30-32." I have been unable to locate this manuscript. It cannot be Müller and Nanjio (1884) for example. In Conze (1967, 154) the reference is simply "MM pp. 30-32".

56. I thank Chris Jones for pointing out an example of this opposition in Nāgārjuna's *Ratnāvalī*: https://www2.hf.uio.no/polyglotta/index.php?page=record&view=record&vid=1123&mid=1942587

57. See *Digital Dictionary of Buddhism* http://www.buddhism-dict.net/cgi-bin/xpr-ddb.pl?q=真實

58. See *Digital Dictionary of Buddhism* http://www.buddhism-dict.net/cgi-bin/xpr-ddb.pl?q=虛

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Dhāraṇī

故說般若波羅蜜多咒即說呪曰　揭帝　揭帝　般羅揭帝　般羅僧揭帝　菩提薩婆訶。

Therefore recite the incantation of perfect insight, that is, recite the incantation [that goes] like this: *jiēdì jiēdì bānluójiēdì bānluósēngjiēdì pútí sàpóhē.*

prajñāpāramitāyām ukto mantraḥ tadyathā | gate gate pāragate pārasaṃgate bodhi svāhā ||

Concerning perfect insight, a mantra is said like this: *gate gate pāragate pārasaṃgate bodhi svāhā*

The final lines of the text are an introduction to the *dhāraṇī* and the *dhāraṇī* itself. As noted above, the *dhāraṇī* was likely copied from the *Tuóluóní jí jīng* «陀羅尼集經» **Dhāraṇīsamuccaya* (T901 [18] 807.b19-26) translated by Atikūṭa in 654 CE. In addition, similar *dhāraṇī* can be found in the *Dōngfāng zuì shèng dēng wáng tuóluóní jīng* «東方最勝燈王陀羅尼經» **Agrapradīpadhāraṇīvidyārāja-sūtra* (T1353 [21] 867c12-c22) translated in the Sui Dynasty (581–618 CE) by *Jñānagupta, and in the *Dàfāng děng wú xiǎng jīng* «大方等無想經» (*Mahāmegha Sutra*) (T387 [12] 1048c7, c12), translated by Tán Wúchèn 曇無讖 "Dharmakṣema" ca. 414–442 CE. Nattier (1992, 211 n.53) comments that "the striking similarities between them suggests that a number of variants of this mantra must have been circulating out of the context of the *Heart Sutra* itself."

Introduction

故說般若波羅蜜多咒即說呪曰

Therefore recite the incantation of perfect insight, that is, recite the incantation [that goes] like this:

prajñāpāramitāyām ukto mantraḥ tadyathā

The spell recited concerning perfect insight goes like this:

The unrevised text from CBETA includes the opening phrase in the preceding paragraph, that is,

「故知般若波羅蜜多是大神咒、是大明咒、是無上咒、是無等等咒，能除一切苦，真實不虛，故說般若波羅蜜多咒。」(T251 [8] 848c17-18).

Know that perfect insight is the great expertise, unexcelled expertise, and unequalled expertise; it can remove all suffering; it is true and not false, therefore recite the incantation of perfect insight.

In this case, we have to read what is left—*jí shuō zhòu yuē* 即說呪曰—as a standalone phrase meaning something like "recite the incantation this way." In this context, we expect to see *tadyathā* "in this way," which is often translated as *jí shuō* 即說.[59]

The counterpart in *Hṛd* is quite difficult to parse since the verb is a passive past participle *uktaḥ* (from √*vac*) meaning "spoken." *Prajñāpāramitāyām* is the locative singu-

59. Also *suǒwèi* 所謂, and sometimes transliterated as *dánǐyětā* 咀你也他, *dánǐyětā* 咀儞也他, and *dátā* 怛他.

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lar, which can be read as "in Prajñāpāramitā" or "with respect to Prajñāpāramitā." So the phrase may be read as "in Prajñāpāramitā a mantra is spoken" or "concerning Prajñāpāramitā a mantra is spoken." The passive past participle may also be read with a perfect sense, that is, "with respect to Prajñāpāramitā a mantra *was* spoken." By contrast, the Chinese verb *shuō* 說 "recite," given the expected benefits seen in Section 4, appears to be a recommendation. Thus, if √*vac* is the appropriate verb, we might have expected a conjugation such as *vāca* "you must recite" (second person singular imperative) or *vācayitavyā* "it should be recited" (future passive participle).[60]

Text of the *dhāraṇī*

揭帝　揭帝　般羅揭帝　般羅僧揭帝　菩提　薩婆訶。

gate gate pāragate pārasaṃgate bodhi svāhā ||

Here at least, *Xīn* and *Hṛd* appear to be entirely comparable. There is a minor variation in the transcription of *gate* or *jiēdì* 揭帝; the Fangshan Stele (the oldest *Heart Sutra* text)[61] and a few other sources have *jiēdì* 揭諦 (with no change in pronunciation). The Chinese transcription of *svāhā* is variable.

Transcription	Found in
shā hē 莎訶	*Tuóluóní jí jīng* «陀羅尼集經», T901 (18) 807b19-21. Kuījī's commentary, T1710 (33) 542c8.
sà pó hē 薩婆訶	The Fangshan Stele (see Attwood 2019, 8) Fǎzàng commentary, T1712 (33) 555a6.
shā pó hē 莎婆呵.	Woncheuk's commentary, T1711 (33) 551c10.
sēng shā hē 僧莎訶	T250 (8) 847c28. T251 (8) 848.c22.

The retention of *sēng shā hē* 僧莎訶 in the Taishō edition is surprising because adding *sēng* 僧 to *shā hē* 莎訶 is an obvious mistake.[62] Moreover, the version of *Xīn* in popular use follows the older canons in using *sà pó hē* 薩婆訶, where *sà pó* 薩婆 is an attempt to convey the conjunct consonant *sva*. Zhang (2019, 10–13) notes that this variability in the transcription of *svāhā* continues through later versions of the Chinese *Heart Sutra*, though the extended texts are most likely translations from Sanskrit.

Signe Cohen (2002) persuasively argues that the *–e* ending, common in Buddhist *dhāraṇī*, likely reflects a Buddhist Hybrid Sanskrit or Prakrit masculine nominative singular case ending (for nouns in *-a*) rather than a Classical Sanskrit case ending. Contrast this with Conze's (1958, 106) speculations that it reflects a "masculine locative singular" or a "feminine vocative singular," neither of which makes any sense in this context. *Bodhi* is also in the nominative singular and *svāhā* is considered indeclinable (though it derives from the past perfect *āha* "was said").

60. Compare Vaidya 1960, 4, and throughout.

61. On this oldest version of the *Heart Sutra*, see Attwood 2019.

62. This is likely due to an eye-skip from the previous word: *bānluó sēngjiēdì* 般羅僧揭帝.

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Conclusion

Comparing *Xīn* and *Hṛd*, we find numerous significant differences. For example, in section 1.2, I noted that *svabhāva* occurs in *Hṛd* but not *Xīn*. I argued that this appears to be an interpolation in *Hṛd* and is suggestive of Madhyamaka influence on *Hṛd* that is not apparent in *Xīn*. I noted that *Hṛd* lacks a counterpart to *dù yīqiè kǔ è* 度一切苦厄 (section 1.3), and to *māyā* (section 3.1), which I take to be omissions.[63]

The most common type of differences, however, take the form of mismatched expressions. We can cite, for example, section 2.2, in which *Xīn* and *Hṛd* have different subjects (all dharmas vs. *śūnyatā*) and discuss qualities using entirely different words and syntax. The whole of section 3 is different in *Xīn* and *Hṛd*, and the expressions in *Hṛd* are not what we expect to see if that text had been copied from *Pañc*. In particular, we might cite the differences between *xīn wú guà*'ài 心無罣礙 and *viharaty acittāvaraṇaḥ.*

As with previous comparative studies of the *Heart Sutra* (Nattier 1992, Huifeng 2014, Attwood 2021b), the evidence presented here is consistent with *Xīn* being created in Chinese and later being back-translated to create *Hṛd*. Importantly, the text of *Hṛd* cannot have been copied directly from *Pañc*, since the extant texts are different. However, this does not make sense of all the differences. Even accepting that *Hṛd* is a translation of *Xīn* rather than the reverse, does not reconcile the two. To say that *Hṛd* is a back-translation is insufficient to explain the differences. In my view, *Hṛd* was back-translated by someone who had a limited Sanskrit vocabulary and was unfamiliar with the idioms of Prajñāpāramitā. This means explaining some of the differences as poor translation choices. As quotidian as this sounds, it is difficult to avoid this conclusion after a close comparative reading. Jeffrey Kotyk (2021) has noted that very few people in China, in any period, were competent Sanskritists. So almost no one could have read and understood *Hṛd* after it was created. Notably, all the early commentaries were focused on the Chinese text (even when a Sanskrit text was ostensibly available). Thus, the fact that it is a *poor* translation does not undermine the scenario in which a manuscript of *Hṛd* that was made in China was passed off as an Indian Buddhist sutra to secure the authenticity of *Xīn*.

Nattier (1992, 179) noted that while we do not know who made *Xīn*, the close association of *Xīn* and Xuánzàng is strong circumstantial evidence of his involvement. That said, the problems associated with *Hṛd* would seem to point away from involvement by Xuánzàng since *Hṛd* doesn't display the level of competence we expect him to possess. That is to say, there are numerous plausible links from Xuánzàng to *Xīn*, but not from Xuánzàng to *Hṛd*.

Lastly, I hope readers will agree that framing the *Heart Sutra* as being primarily concerned with the cessation of sensory experience and the subsequent state of absence (of sensory experience) is a useful explanatory paradigm. In my view, this reading explains a great deal more than the normative, Madhyamaka influenced, metaphysical approaches that presently dominate *Heart Sutra* exegesis.

63. The phrase *tryadhvavyavasthitāḥ sarvabuddhāḥ* as a calque of *sānshì zhū fó* 三世諸佛 "buddhas of the three times" [section 3.2) has already been discussed at length in Attwood (2018b).

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Abbreviations

Aṣṭa	*Aṣṭasāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā*
Hṛd	*Prajñāpāramitāhṛdaya*
MĀ	*Madhyamāgama*
Móhē	*Móhē bānrě bōluómì jīng* «摩訶般若波羅蜜經» (T223)
Pañc	*Pañcaviṃśatisāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā*
Xīn	*Bānrě bōluómìduō xīn jīng* «般若波羅蜜多心經» (T251)

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